

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Epiphany 5
The Light of Reconnecting
1 February 2026



The Life of Harriet Tubman No. 10 (1939-1940)
by Jacob Lawrence

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on ABBOT'S LEIGH and ST. DENIO

Chorale Prelude PANTHERA ROSEA (Henry Mancini, arr. C. Bull)

March of the Resistance (John Williams)

Ciacona ex d, BWV 1178 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

When Felix met J.S. (Bull after Bach and Mendelssohn)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Claire Kelly & Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Lulu & Esme Gregoropoulos

When hope invites us to journey,
elusive, beckoning onward
but never in our grasp:
God of wisdom and promise
give us courage to travel on.

When dreams glimmer in the distance,
fading, clouded, and hidden
or shining with new brightness:
God of wisdom and promise
give us courage to travel on.

When established patterns collapse
into the uncertainty of the unknown
and security dissolves into a memory:
God of wisdom and promise
give us courage to travel on.

When the illusion of success
threatens to divert us
and silence our souls' yearning:
God of wisdom and promise
give us courage to travel on.

When we think our journey has ended
in the star-lit glow only to find
the end is a new beginning:
God of wisdom and promise
give us courage to travel on. [JBerry/ssb]

On this continuing journey of Epiphany,
we gather to rest and to dream,
knowing that we follow the path
of Jesus, as we travel this road together.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Let Justice Like Waters Roll Down

ST. DENIO

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us, O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever-flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.

Pure wisdom and justice flow forth from your hand;
With you as our guide evil forces disband.
Give us, O Christ Jesus, the grace to prevail
O'er systems and powers that keep captives held.

O may we flow freely like waters and streams
To heal and restore broken hearts and lost dreams.
Awaken us fully to all we can be,
Reclaiming our souls as we set people free.

-lyrics Jann Alredge-Clanton, adapted

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

God of the collective,
we awaken this day to your presence,
and to your hope that all find belonging in community.
Many of us long for connection and interdependence,
but we have become used to enduring the sounds of our own loneliness.
We've become so acquainted with loss and abandonment
that we struggle to believe there are those who truly want to be with us.

Keep us from pushing them away.

Form us to be people of collective responsibility,
that we would never become too familiar with solitary independence
but would find ourselves participating in communal restoration and care.

*May we find here, and be here, a people who can hold our lament and rouse our laughter,
those who name their needs and allow space for ours.*

*Let us belong to one another in true mutuality,
knowing our burdens and hopes and liberation are mysteriously entwined.
Let us bear this life together.*

-Cole Arthur Riley

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"The Word Was God"
Laude, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

ROSEPHANYE POWELL

***The Lord's Prayer**

Emily Kang

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.*

*And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Claire Kelly

There is no greater service
that we offer than to heal the sick,
to clothe the unclothed,
to find water for those who thirst,
to bind up the broken-hearted.

*Much is asked of us only because we know, in our depths,
that we are capable.*

As we reconnect with the gifts of peace and hope in this hour,
may we fill our hearts to overflowing with an urgent need
to do the work to which we are called.

*On this day, may we overflow in our zeal for a realm of justice and peace
and equity for all.*

[gvosper]

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from 1 Kings 19*

Juniper Fayazova & Emily Kang

This is the Gospel of Grace...

Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Inhale: We honor our limits. **Exhale:** This breath is enough.

Inhale: We honor this breath. **Exhale:** We behold the beauty.

Inhale: We resist despair. **Exhale:** We protect our dreaming.

-Cole Arthur Riley

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of every beautiful thing,
Reconnect us this day with wonder.
Show us how to hold on to nuance and vision
when our souls become addicted to pain, to the unlovely.
It is far easier to see the gloom and decay;
so often it sings a louder song.
Attune our hearts to the good still stirring in our midst,
not that we would give ourselves to toxic positivity
or neglect the pain of the world,
but that we would be people capable of existing in the tension.

Grant us habits of sacred pause.
Let us marvel not just at the grand or majestic,
but beauty's name etched into every ordinary moment.
Let the mundane swell with a mystery
that makes us breathe deeper still.
And by this, may we be sustained in our dreaming
and kept from despair.

-Cole Arthur Riley

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

"To Sit And Dream"

ROSEPHANYE POWELL

Cathedral Choir and Commonwealth, Brandon Harris, *Commonwealth Director*

"To sit and dream, to sit and read, To sit and learn about the world outside our world of here and now— Our problem world--to dream of vast horizons of the soul through dreams made whole, Unfettered, free--help me! All you who are dreamers, too, help me to make our world anew. I reach out my dreams to you." ~Langston Hughes

Sermon

The Light of Reconnecting

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Claire Kelly

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"I Dream A World"
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Assistant Director

ROSEPHANYE POWELL

"I dream a world where all no other will scorn, where love will bless the earth And peace its paths adorn. I dream a world where all will know sweet freedom's way, where greed no longer saps the soul, nor avarice blights our day. A world I dream where black or white, whatever race you be, will share the bounties of the earth and everyone is free, where wretchedness will hang its head And joy, like a pearl, attends the needs of humankind-Of such I dream, my world!" ~Langston Hughes

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Offering Prayer

Esme Gregoropoulos

O God who calls, may we listen.
We are grateful that you stir in us a momentum toward particular giftings and desires. Help us to listen for what's true in us, that we would enter our shared purpose freely. Keep us from being enticed by goals that are grounded outside of our deepest values. Liberate us from that sinister temptation to build our lives on the quicksand of toxic individualism. Make our calling both personal and collective, that our hopes would be grafted onto the shared hope that has sustained people across time.

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

So may you fall in love again and again with the beautiful.
And may that enchantment keep you
from the captivity of despair
and usher you into dreaming.
In your beholding, may you become a faithful protector
of every person and piece of creation,
including the earth that trembles beneath your feet.
Go in peace, to pay attention.
-Cole Arthur Riley

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Arise, Beloved"
Cathedral Choir

ROSEPHANYE POWELL

*Hymn for the Journey

All the Colors of the Rainbow

ABBOT'S LEIGH

All the colors of the rainbow live unseen in daily light,
But their splendors find expression when released to human sight;
So the church reveals most beauty where diversity is real:
Breadth of race and class and gender, room for doubt and space to heal.

All the body's parts are wanted, nor can one despise the rest:
Head and hand must work together, as must eye and ear and chest;
So the church needs all its members for a range of ministries:
Varied gifts with one great mission, "Do this for the least of these."

Every language gains more music when the words for peace appear:
Pax, Salaam, Eirini, Heiwa, Pace, Santi, Frieden, Mir.
Though our tongues make sounds that vary all bespeak a common home:
Longing for the end of conflict and a new life in God's Shalom.

Teach us, God, our need of others; through them help us fully live.
Wean us from our selfish habits; let us listen, learn, forgive.
May we see your longed-for image in each human heart and face,
And behold how those around us can be channels of your grace.

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Prelude in C minor from *Das Wohltemperierte Klavier* (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Inside The Music

"Dr. Rosephanye Powell teaches at Auburn University and has become a well-respected and widely-performed choral composer over the last few decades. Her music often draws on her gospel and RnB roots. She mingles those sounds into fresh, new creations. She is also fond of setting Black poets, and Langston Hughes tends to be a favorite. "To Sit And Dream" reveals the deep horrors of state-sponsored terror in a wistful and hopeful reflection of life. Hughes asks the question of what it would feel like to live unburdened by societal oppression such that he could just rest and dream. Hughes was writing in the early part of the 20th century. It's easy to forget that oppression creates an ongoing stress that affects a person's everyday life, not just moments of acute violence. Powell answers Hughes' wistfulness with her own. Short, ephemeral phrases seem to disappear into the air at first. They are followed by chromatic runs on "outside our world" that scratch the surface of this dream. As the hopeful nature of the piece appears, the lines grow broader and more insistent. When she arrives on "I reach out my hand to you" she loops the phrase over and again. What Hughes said in hope, Powell insists upon bringing into practice. We have come too far, she seems to be saying, to not pick up this message and do something with it. Her setting of his famous "I Dream A World" has been a favorite of ours for some years. Similarly to "To Sit And Dream" she uses broad phrases at the beginning to underscore the most hopeful text. As she moves to the center of the poem that describes the mechanisms of an equitable world, her music becomes mechanistic. You can hear the churning of a society moving toward something new, even as you hear the tension of change caught within the wheels. Her signature chromaticism shines as phrases fall upon phrases illuminating the breadth of human experience and the promises of diverse cultures living in harmony. Her setting of the first three verses of John 1 musically cut through the air like light breaking through the clouds. Her pert syncopation and gospel-derived punctuations groove as parts build on each other in a counterpoint style borrowed from the same

tradition. We close with an excerpt from her “Arise Beloved” setting from Song of Solomon. Like in “I Dream A World,” this piece is endlessly hopeful. Its expansive organ riff and long choral lines make us feel as if we can shake off the hardship of the past and move forward together into a dreamed about future.” ~ Dr. David Harris

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